



FLIP THROUGH BEFORE YOU DOWNLOAD

Nobody Should Know Which One They Got

Three real pages, straight off the shipping files,
plus everything the full download includes.



What the research actually says

I expected to open this page with "research shows labeling harms students." **I went and read it, and it does not say that.** Here is what it does say, because you should have the real version before you change anything in your room.

The best-known meta-analysis found the opposite of a crisis

Kulik and Kulik, 1984, pooling **31 studies** of ability grouping in elementary schools, reported "**significant positive effects on the academic performance of elementary school children**" — a small benefit, moving a typical student from the 50th to the 58th percentile.

And on the part this page is about, the same analysis found grouping had "**trivially small effects on the self-concepts of elementary school pupils.**" Not devastating. Trivially small.

The concerns are real but contested, and later work is mixed

There is a long literature on placement bias and on students in low groups internalizing what the group says about them, and there is also work finding no such contrast effect. **Anybody who takes this question is settled has not read enough of it.**

So why hide the tier at all?

Because the argument was never the research. **It is that the label does nothing.** Ask what a student is supposed to do differently on learning they are on tier two. There is no answer. It carries no instruction, no next step and no way to improve — **it is a fact about them rather than about their work.**

And that makes it a cheap decision rather than a brave one

You are not weighing a benefit against a risk. **You are removing something with no upside and an argued-about downside,** and page 3 says what it costs to remove: four things have to match. That is the whole price.

SNEAK PEEK · 5 pages

Match these, or the tier shows anyway

Children are extremely good at this. Hiding the label is not enough if everything else gives it away, and these are the four that give it away.

1 • The same questions

Not easier questions for the easier passage. **The same question bank at every level.** If the questions differ, the versions are visibly different work and the whole thing collapses the moment two students compare. It also keeps the assessment honest: you are changing how hard the *reading* is, not what you are asking them to know.

2 • The same key terms

Every version uses the real vocabulary. **Simplifying the sentences is differentiation; removing the words of the subject is a different and smaller course.** A student on the simplest version still says "photosynthesis" still writes it, still owns it.

3 • The same look and roughly the same length

Same font, same layout, same number of paragraphs, same paper. **No colored paper, no letters in the corner, no "Version B."** Two sheets the same size, same desk tell a room nothing.

4 • The same expectations out loud

Same deadline, same instructions, same tone when you hand it over. **This is the one that leaks,** and it leaks through kindness — "take your time with this one" said gently to one table announces the whole system.

And one rule about movement.

When a student moves up a level, **say nothing and change nothing visible.** The reward for getting better is not an announcement; it is that the work fits again. If moving up is an event, then being moved down is an event too, and you have rebuilt the label with extra steps.

SNEAK PEEK • 5 pages

Six ways to do this on paper tomorrow

- 1 Print both versions identically**
Same paper, same font, same header. **If you need to tell them apart, put a tiny mark where you will look and a student will not** — a dot in the footer, a different staple corner. Not a letter in the top right.
- 2 Hand them out face down, in seating order**
Sorted beforehand. The thirty seconds of sorting at your desk replaces the entire visible system, and no student watches you decide anything.
- 3 Give the same instructions to the whole room**
One set, said once, to everybody. **Any instruction that only makes sense for one version is a leak.**
- 4 Keep the questions identical and put them on a separate sheet**
One question sheet for the room, handed out to everybody. Now the only thing that differs is the reading, which is the only thing you wanted to differ.
- 5 Never name a group after what it is**
If you must group, name them after nothing — colors, rivers, anything arbitrary. **Do not change the membership often enough that the names stop meaning anything.** A group name that is stable all year is a label whatever you call it.
- 6 Move students quietly and often**
Small, frequent, unannounced adjustments. **Movement that is normal is not news**, and a system where nobody can be sure who is on what is a system where it stops mattering.

SNEAK PEEK · 5 pages

The test for whether it worked.

Ask a student which version they got. If they can tell you, something on this page is not being done. If they look at you blankly, you have it.



WHAT IS INSIDE

Nobody Should Know Which One They Got

- ✓ Why the label does no teaching work
- ✓ What the research actually says, with the source named
- ✓ The four things that must match, or the tier shows
- ✓ The rule about moving a student up
- ✓ Six ways to do it on paper, no software
- ✓ A fill-in page to find your own leaks

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